THE INVASION OF Tibet and the policy of deference towards China that had preceded it, finally galvanized into action those members of Nehru's Cabinet who had misgivings about the direction of India's foreign policy and the threat it represented to India's security. On 1 November, there was a furious exchange of notes on Tibet and China between C. Rajagopalachari and Nehru.[60] At the Cabinet meeting on 2 November 1950, there was again a sharp and heated exchange between the two. Patel, who had attended at fifteen minutes' notice and been unable to read his papers beforehand, sat silently, preferring to bide his time and build his case.[61] The next day he received a detailed briefing on the subject from Bajpai and a paper on the situation from the Intelligence Bureau – based on which his letter to Nehru was prepared. Bajpai argued that while India was unprepared for war, it should cease its advocacy of China's claim to be admitted to the UN and prepare to defend the McMahon line.[62]

In his celebrated letter of 7 November 1950, Patel deprecated the pathetic state of Indian diplomacy and called for a comprehensive review of Sino-Indian relations: a military and intelligence evaluation of the Chinese threat, a long-term reconsideration of India's defence needs in terms of supplies and infrastructure and the twin threats from China and Pakistan, examination and redisposition of forces to guard important areas that may be subject to dispute, improvement of communications in these areas, political and administrative steps to strengthen frontier governance and an end to India's advocacy of China's entry into the UN. 'Recent and bitter history also tells us,' Patel observed, 'that communism is no shield against imperialism.'

'It is possible,' he continued, 'that a consideration of these matters may lead us into wider questions of our relationship with China, Russia, America, Britain and Burma.' Patel thus hinted that his concerns were not limited to China – and held out the tantalizing possibility that a fundamental reset of the general orientation of India's foreign policy and its position in the Cold War was on the cards. He did not elaborate, making it impossible to determine with certainty how far he was willing to go to demand such a